

### Author's Note

**P**rofessor Johnson Agharese Egonmwan is an accomplished scholar, public administrator, and development policy expert with over four decades of distinguished service in governance and academia.

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His scholarly works and policy briefs have profoundly influenced discourses on governance, federalism, and institutional reform in Nigeria. He has received numerous national and international awards, including recognition from the West African Institute of Research and Administration, the International Consortium on Governmental Financial Management (ICGFM), USA, and the Institute of Policy Management Nigeria (IPMN).

He is currently the Managing Director and CEO of Resyin (NG) Co. Consults, and a dedicated advocate for peace, equitable governance, and sustainable development in Africa.

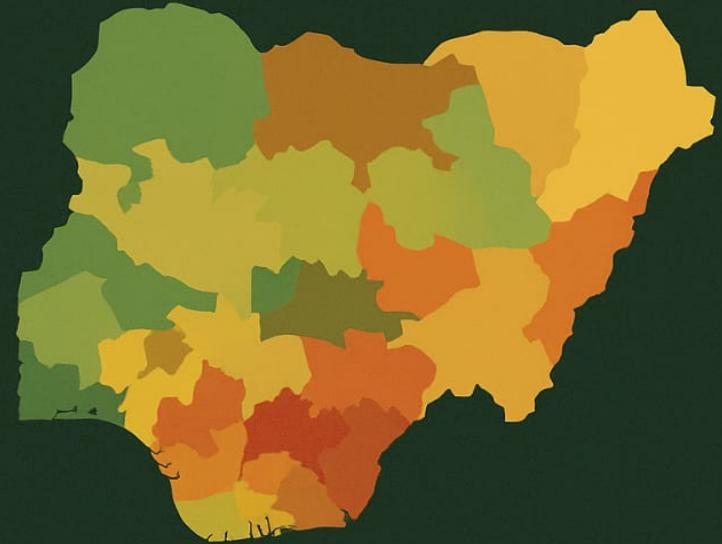
RETHINKING NIGERIA

PROF. JOHNSON AGHARESE EGONMWAN

# RETHINKING NIGERIA

## DECENTRALIZATION AND DEVOLUTION IN STATEHOOD

APPLICATIONS AND LESSONS FOR  
EMERGING AND POST-COLONIAL STATES



**PROF. JOHNSON  
AGHARESE EGONMWAN** DMA®



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## Preface

This book, *Rethinking Nigeria: Models for Peaceful Transition to Independent Nation-States*, emerged from decades of research, policy engagement, and reflection on the structural contradictions that define Nigeria's federal experience. The study is not a call for disintegration, but a sober invitation to rethink how the Nigerian state can evolve peacefully into a community of self-governing entities that are united by choice rather than by coercion.

Nigeria's complexity as a multi-ethnic, multi-religious, and resource-diverse federation presents both challenges and opportunities. Its diversity has too often been managed through centralization and bureaucratic uniformity, producing tension, inefficiency, and alienation. Yet this same diversity, if nurtured through devolution, inclusivity, and local empowerment, can become the foundation of peace, innovation, and sustainable development.

The book blends academic analysis with pragmatic policy thinking. Drawing on comparative federal models from across the world — including India, Switzerland, Canada, and the United Kingdom — it presents a set of pathways for Nigeria's transition toward a more functional and equitable federation or confederation. The goal is to illuminate the options for policymakers, scholars, and citizens who seek a lasting solution to



the persistent crises of governance and unity.

I am indebted to scholars, colleagues, and policymakers whose insights over the years have deepened my understanding of Nigeria's governance dynamics. This work continues my long-standing engagement with the question of how African states, born of colonial amalgamations, can become true nations — self-defining, cooperative, and peaceable.

It is my hope that this book will contribute to the national and continental conversation on peaceful restructuring and governance reform, inspiring further dialogue, research, and action toward a more balanced, just, and sustainable Nigeria.

Prof. Johnson Agharese Egonmwan

Benin City, Nigeria

November 2025

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## Acknowledgments

This work draws on the contributions of many individuals and institutions that have shaped my intellectual and professional journey.

I acknowledge the inspiration and mentorship of my academic colleagues at the University of Benin, the Institute of Development Studies, and the Civil Service Training Institute, Edo State, where many of the ideas in this volume were first debated and refined.

My gratitude also goes to the World Bank, UNDP, UNICEF, WHO, UK-DFID, and the EU Delegation to Nigeria, for providing platforms through which I have worked on public financial management, decentralization, and governance reform — experiences that enriched the policy dimensions of this study.

Special thanks are due to Resyin (NG) Consults, whose publishing and research support made this manuscript possible, and to my family for their patience and encouragement throughout the research and writing process.

To the people of Nigeria — resilient, diverse, and hopeful — this book is dedicated. It is for you, and about you.



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## Narrative Analysis: GDP-to-Population Ratios and National Implications

The ratios presented in Table 1.4 reveal profound structural imbalances within Nigeria's political economy. At the heart of these disparities is the reality that economic output and population distribution are mismatched across the six geopolitical zones. This disconnect has deep implications for governance, development planning, and the sustainability of the federation.

The South South emerges as the most striking outlier. With only 9% of Nigeria's population, it contributes a staggering 40% of GDP, producing a GDP-to-population ratio of 4.44. This disproportionate contribution reflects the region's dominance in oil and gas production, which has historically underpinned Nigeria's fiscal revenues. Yet, the paradox is evident: despite this immense contribution, the South South has long suffered neglect in infrastructural development, environmental protection, and equitable resource distribution. This imbalance fuels grievances that have manifested in militancy, resource control agitations, and calls for greater regional autonomy.

In contrast, the North West and North East together hold almost 40% of the nation's population but contribute barely 13% of GDP. With GDP-to-population ratios of 0.32 and 0.36 respectively, these zones are significantly underperforming economically relative to their demographic weight. The implications are stark:



high dependency ratios, widespread poverty, food insecurity, and persistent governance challenges. The imbalance also contributes to regional instability, as economic deprivation feeds insurgencies and cross-border criminal activities.

The North Central zone, while endowed with vast mineral resources and agricultural potential, also underperforms with a GDP-to-population ratio of 0.48. Ethno-religious conflicts, herder–farmer crises, and weak exploitation of mineral deposits have constrained its capacity to translate resources into productivity.

On the other hand, the South West displays a GDP-to-population ratio of 1.25, making it the most economically balanced zone. Its diversified economy — spanning manufacturing, finance, services, and ICT — makes it less vulnerable to the volatility of oil revenues. Similarly, the South East achieves a near balance (1.09), sustained by a vibrant commercial culture, diaspora remittances, and a strong network of small and medium-scale enterprises (SMEs).

These disparities underscore the fragility of Nigeria's current federal system. The over-reliance on the South South's oil wealth to sustain the entire federation, coupled with the demographic pressures in the North, creates structural tensions. The South West and South East demonstrate that diversification and human capital investment can generate more balanced development, but



these lessons have yet to be adopted nationwide.

From a policy perspective, the data call for urgent rethinking of Nigeria's federal model. Key policy questions arise:

How can resource revenues be managed more equitably to reduce regional grievances?

What structural reforms can help the North leverage its demographic strength into economic productivity?

Can fiscal federalism and decentralization incentivize zones to maximize their unique comparative advantages?

Unless these imbalances are addressed through inclusive reforms, Nigeria risks deepening regional inequalities, weakening national cohesion, and perpetuating cycles of conflict and underdevelopment.



## CHAPTER 1

### THE CASE FOR RETHINKING NIGERIA'S STRUCTURE

The evidence presented in this chapter makes one reality inescapable: Nigeria's present federal structure is fundamentally imbalanced and unsustainable. The comparative analysis of GDP contributions, population distribution, and zonal resource endowments highlights the stark mismatch between demographic weight and economic productivity. While the South South sustains the federation through oil and gas revenues, its population remains marginal compared to the burden it carries. Conversely, the North West and North East shoulder the largest demographic pressure but generate far less economic output.

These disparities have deepened structural inequalities, fostered resentment, and perpetuated instability. They explain why fiscal transfers and revenue allocation remain contentious and why agitation for restructuring grows louder across regions. Without deliberate reforms, Nigeria's political economy will continue to be characterized by dependence on oil rents, uneven development, and recurring conflict.

The data also point to pathways for transformation. The South West and South East illustrate that regional economies anchored on diversification, entrepreneurship, and human capital



investment can achieve balance between population and GDP. Their models offer lessons for other zones, demonstrating that prosperity is possible when economic policy is aligned with demographic realities and comparative advantage.

Ultimately, the call to rethink Nigeria is not just a matter of political expediency but of survival. To secure stability, equity, and prosperity, Nigeria must confront its internal contradictions and reimagine a structure that allows its constituent parts to flourish as cooperative yet autonomous entities. This means moving beyond over-centralization, embracing fiscal federalism, and granting regions the authority to harness their unique strengths.

This conclusion sets the stage for the next chapter, which explores the historical foundations of Nigeria's federal contradictions, tracing them back to the amalgamation of 1914 and the missed opportunities for restructuring in the century that followed. By situating today's challenges in historical perspective, we can better understand why the current system is failing and what alternative



models may hold promise for peaceful transitioning into viable nation-states.



## CHAPTER 2

### HISTORICAL FOUNDATIONS OF NIGERIA'S FEDERAL CONTRADICTIONS

#### 2.1 The 1914 Amalgamation and Its Motives

The origins of Nigeria's present contradictions lie in the British amalgamation of 1914, when the Protectorate of Northern Nigeria and the Colony and Protectorate of Southern Nigeria were fused into a single political unit. This amalgamation was not driven by the will of the peoples inhabiting these territories but by British administrative convenience and economic calculation.

The North had a revenue deficit that was sustained by annual grants from Britain.

The South, especially the Western and Eastern regions, generated sufficient revenue through duties and exports.

Amalgamation thus allowed British officials to use Southern surpluses to subsidize the North.

This fiscal motive laid the foundation for enduring grievances: the perception that one region bore the burden of sustaining others. The amalgamation ignored ethnic, cultural, and religious diversity, planting seeds of future discord.



#### 2.2 Early Federal Structures and Regionalism

Between the 1920s and the 1950s, Nigeria witnessed gradual constitutional reforms:

**Clifford Constitution (1922):** Introduced limited elections but centralized power in Lagos.

**Richards Constitution (1946):** For the first time, recognized Nigeria's regional diversity — North, West, East — but left the Governor with overriding authority.

**Macpherson Constitution (1951):** Expanded regional autonomy with regional legislatures.

**Lyttleton Constitution (1954):** Formally introduced federalism, making Nigeria a federation of regions with significant autonomy.

This federal system allowed the three main regions to grow along their strengths:

The North focused on groundnut pyramids and cotton.

The West developed cocoa, education, and an early civil service.

The East advanced palm oil, trade, and industry.

The period demonstrated that regional competition and autonomy encouraged innovation and prosperity.



### 2.3 The Independence Settlement of 1960

When Nigeria attained independence in 1960, the federal structure was retained, with four regions after the creation of the Mid-West in 1963. Each region had its constitution, coat of arms, and even controlled its own civil service and police.

However, political elites feared domination by the more populous North, while minorities demanded recognition. Ethnic politics and mistrust of the federal center grew stronger, culminating in:

The 1966 coups and subsequent civil war (1967–1970).

The 12-state creation decree of 1967 by General Gowon, which dismantled regionalism.

### 2.4 Centralization under Military Rule

From 1966 onward, Nigeria shifted from federalism to unitary centralism disguised as federalism. Military rulers seized regional powers, concentrated fiscal authority in the federal government, and introduced a federal allocation system that redistributed oil revenues.

States became dependent on Abuja rather than their internal resources.

Oil wealth from the Niger Delta replaced regional agriculture as the lifeline of the federation.

The federal government assumed control of education, police, and revenue, eroding autonomy.



This over-centralization bred inefficiency, corruption, and the “sharing mentality” that defines Nigeria's fiscal politics today.

### 2.5 The Missed Opportunity of 2014

The 2014 National Conference, convened by President Goodluck Jonathan, brought together over 490 delegates from across the country. Its recommendations included:

Greater fiscal federalism (states to control resources and pay royalties to the center).

Creation of state police.

Reduction of exclusive federal powers.

Reorganization of Nigeria into six geo-political zones as federating units.

These proposals represented a roadmap for peaceful restructuring. Unfortunately, they were shelved, leaving unresolved the contradictions planted in 1914.

### 2.6 Timeline of Nigeria's Structural Shifts

(To be inserted as Figure 2.1: A horizontal timeline)

1914 – Amalgamation

1946 – Richards Constitution (regionalism recognized)

1954 – Federalism under Lyttleton Constitution

1960 – Independence, 3 Regions (later 4 in 1963)

1966–1970 – Military rule, coups, civil war



1967 – 12 states created, regions abolished  
1979 – Presidential system introduced  
1999 – Return to civil rule, 36-state federal structure  
2014 – National Conference recommends restructuring

## 2.7 Analysis

The Nigerian federation has oscillated between true federalism and disguised unitarism. While the regions once demonstrated viability and healthy competition, military centralization and the politics of oil rents eroded autonomy. The central government today is both overburdened and distrusted.

This history shows that Nigeria's crisis is not new but deeply rooted in the mismatch between imposed structures and the realities of its diversity.

## Conclusion of Chapter 2

The historical trajectory of Nigeria's federal experiment demonstrates a persistent tension between unity imposed from above and diversity expressed from below. The 1914 amalgamation, conceived without the consent of the constituent peoples, established a polity held together primarily by colonial interests rather than shared aspirations. Although federal constitutions in the 1950s allowed for a measure of autonomy and competitive development, this promise was short-lived. The coups of 1966, the civil war, and the subsequent dismantling of



regionalism under military rule entrenched a centralized system that undermined the federal spirit.

Nigeria's missed opportunities — particularly the shelving of the 2014 National Conference recommendations — further illustrate the gap between the rhetoric of federalism and its practice. The result is a pseudo-federal state, where control of oil wealth by the center sustains a culture of dependency and rent-seeking, while innovation and accountability at the subnational level are stifled.

The lesson from history is clear: political stability, economic viability, and national cohesion are best achieved through genuine federalism or negotiated autonomy. Nigeria's survival and progress depend on revisiting these foundations, acknowledging its plural character, and charting a transition model that aligns structure with reality.

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## CHAPTER 3

# CONTEMPORARY FAULT LINES AND PRESSURES FOR RESTRUCTURING

### Introduction

In modern Nigeria, the demand for restructuring is not a mere political slogan but a manifestation of deep-seated socio-economic and political contradictions. Decades after independence, the country remains a federation in name but a unitary state in practice, where real power, revenue, and authority are concentrated in Abuja. This over-centralization has intensified grievances across Nigeria's six geopolitical zones, giving rise to competing narratives of marginalization, injustice, and exclusion.

Understanding these fault lines is crucial for building a viable roadmap toward peaceful transitioning into autonomous, cooperative nation-states.

### Ethno-Religious Fault Lines

Nigeria is home to over 250 ethnic groups and adherents of multiple religions. While diversity should be a source of strength, the failure to manage pluralism has produced polarization.

In the North, religion has become a dominant identity marker, with the entrenchment of Sharia law in 12 states creating



recurring flashpoints.

In the South, ethnic self-determination movements such as IPOB (Indigenous People of Biafra) and Niger Delta militants frame their struggle in terms of resource control and historical injustice..

The rise of ethnic militias, religious violence, and separatist rhetoric are not isolated events but symptoms of a federation unable to balance unity with autonomy.

### Economic Fault Lines

Resource distribution remains the sharpest source of contestation.

**Oil Dependency:** Over 80% of national revenue comes from oil located in the South South, yet proceeds are shared nationally, breeding resentment among oil-producing communities.

**Revenue Allocation:** The federally collected revenue is distributed by a formula that favors states with large land mass and population, further straining relations between North and South.

**Unemployment and Poverty:** Youth unemployment averages 33% nationally, with northern states disproportionately affected, creating fertile ground for radicalization and insecurity.

### Governance Fault Lines

Centralized control has produced inefficiency, corruption, and alienation.



Local governments are financially emasculated by state governors, themselves beholden to Abuja for allocations.

The “federal character” principle, designed to promote inclusivity, often undermines meritocracy, while failing to address deeper inequalities.

The result is a fragile legitimacy crisis, where many Nigerians no longer trust that the state represents their collective interest..

### Pressures for Restructuring

**The persistence of these fault lines has generated mounting pressures:**

**Regional Agitations:** The South East demands Biafra, the South South clamors for resource control, the South West campaigns for restructuring, while the North is increasingly concerned about maintaining political dominance.

**Civil Society and Intellectual Advocacy:** Scholars, think tanks, and elder statesmen have consistently called for a return to true federalism.

**Security Challenges:** From Boko Haram to banditry and farmer-herder clashes, insecurity underscores the state's inability to manage diversity and ensure basic welfare.



### Visual Aid: Table 3.1 – Major Fault Lines in Nigeria

| Category        | Manifestations                                 | Consequences                          |
|-----------------|------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------|
| Ethno-Religious | Sharia conflicts, IPOB, ethnic militias        | Violence, separatist agitations       |
| Economic        | Oil dependency, inequitable revenue sharing    | Resentment, underdevelopment          |
| Governance      | Over-centralization, corruption, weak LGAs     | Alienation, legitimacy crisis         |
| Security        | Boko Haram, herders-farmers conflict, banditry | Insecurity, displacement, instability |

### Conclusion

Nigeria's fault lines are neither new nor insurmountable, but their persistence underscores the urgency of systemic change. The pressures for restructuring are born out of legitimate grievances that demand a deliberate rethinking of Nigeria's constitutional framework. Unless these contradictions are addressed through inclusive dialogue and negotiated autonomy, the country risks further polarization and possible disintegration.

This chapter thus prepares the ground for the next section: exploring models of federalism and comparative lessons from other plural societies that Nigeria can adopt in designing its transition to peaceful nation-states.



## CHAPTER 4

### COMPARATIVE MODELS OF FEDERALISM: LESSONS FOR NIGERIA

#### Introduction

Nigeria is not the first deeply plural society to wrestle with questions of identity, diversity, and political cohesion. Around the world, federations have emerged as pragmatic solutions to balance unity with autonomy. By studying these comparative models, Nigeria can extract useful lessons for charting a pathway to peaceful transitioning into viable nation-states or a more genuine federation.

This chapter reviews selected case studies — the United States, India, Canada, Switzerland, and Ethiopia — highlighting their strengths, weaknesses, and implications for Nigeria.

#### The United States: Fiscal Autonomy and Strong States

The United States federation is built on constitutional sovereignty of the states, with powers not expressly given to the federal government reserved for the states. Each state has its own constitution, legislature, and taxation system.

**Strengths:** High degree of fiscal autonomy; citizens identify strongly with both state and nation.



**Weaknesses:** Historical fault lines (e.g., Civil War) reveal risks when regional autonomy challenges national cohesion.

**Lesson for Nigeria:** Nigeria's over-centralization contrasts sharply with U.S. federalism. Greater fiscal autonomy for states could unleash economic creativity and reduce dependence on oil rents.

#### India: Federalism in a Multi-Ethnic, Multi-Religious Context

India's federalism is unique, managing over a billion people and immense cultural diversity. States are created or restructured to accommodate linguistic and ethnic groups, with Article 356 allowing federal intervention when states fail to function.

**Strengths:** Adaptability — new states can be carved out peacefully to meet ethnic demands.

**Weaknesses: Central government sometimes overuses intervention powers.**

**Lesson for Nigeria:** Nigeria could benefit from a flexible federal structure that allows ethnic nationalities to pursue self-determination within a federal framework, rather than being locked in rigid state boundaries.

#### Canada: Balancing Unity with Quebec's Autonomy

Canada balances national unity with Quebec's strong demand for linguistic and cultural recognition. Mechanisms like bilingual federalism, fiscal equalization, and constitutional negotiation



have kept Quebec within the union despite repeated secession referenda.

**Strengths:** Accommodation of minority nationalities without breaking the federation.

**Weaknesses: Recurrent tensions over sovereignty.**

Lesson for Nigeria: Dialogue and constitutional accommodation — rather than suppression — are better tools for managing separatist movements like IPOB or Niger Delta militants.

### Switzerland: Consensus Federalism

Switzerland is a federation of 26 cantons, each enjoying significant autonomy in taxation, language, and education. Decision-making is built on consensus, and multilingualism is celebrated.

**Strengths:** Stability through decentralization and inclusivity.

**Weaknesses:** Consensus can slow decision-making.

Lesson for Nigeria: Switzerland shows that diversity can be managed if institutions are designed for shared rule and self-rule — giving each group a sense of ownership.

### Ethiopia: Ethnic Federalism

Ethiopia offers a cautionary tale. Its ethnic federalism grants regions (ethno-linguistic “nations”) the right to secession. While initially seen as progressive, it has fueled secessionist wars (e.g.,



Tigray conflict).

**Strengths:** Recognition of ethno-national identities.

**Weaknesses:** Weak central cohesion; perpetual risk of fragmentation.

Lesson for Nigeria: Ethnic federalism without strong integrative mechanisms can be destabilizing. Nigeria must avoid a model that incentivizes violent separatism.

### Visual Aid: Table 4.1 – Comparative Federal Models

| Country              | Key Features                       | Strengths                        | Weaknesses                                  |
|----------------------|------------------------------------|----------------------------------|---------------------------------------------|
| Relevance to Nigeria |                                    |                                  |                                             |
| USA                  | State sovereignty, fiscal autonomy | Economic dynamism, innovation    | Risk of fragmentation                       |
|                      |                                    |                                  | Need for fiscal federalism                  |
| India                | Flexible, adaptive state creation  | Diversity managed peacefully     | Central overreach                           |
|                      |                                    |                                  | Possible restructuring along ethnic lines   |
| Canada               | Minority accommodation (Quebec)    | Dialogue prevents disintegration | Repeated sovereignty crises                 |
|                      |                                    |                                  | Negotiated inclusion of marginalized groups |
| Switzerland          | Consensus, canton autonomy         | Stability, inclusivity           | Slower decision-making                      |
|                      |                                    |                                  | Shared rule + self-rule model               |



Ethiopia      Ethnic federalism with right to secede  
Recognition of identities      Violent secession wars  
Caution against excessive ethnic federalism.

### Conclusion

Comparative experience shows that no single federal model is perfect, but all highlight the importance of aligning political structures with social realities. For Nigeria, the urgent lesson is that forced centralization is unsustainable. A genuine federation must emerge, one that combines fiscal autonomy, cultural accommodation, and inclusive governance, while avoiding the pitfalls of unrestrained ethnic fragmentation.

As Nigeria seeks a model for peaceful transition, the next chapter will explore pathways toward fiscal federalism and resource control, offering concrete proposals for restructuring along equitable line.



## CHAPTER 5

### FISCAL FEDERALISM AND RESOURCE CONTROL: PATHWAYS TO EQUITY

#### Introduction

At the heart of Nigeria's structural crisis lies the question of who controls resources and how revenues are shared. The current system, where the federal government controls nearly all major sources of revenue — particularly oil — has entrenched dependency, fueled corruption, and stifled regional initiative. A reimagined Nigeria must embrace fiscal federalism, where subnational units generate and control their resources, remit agreed contributions to the center, and innovate freely within their comparative advantage.

#### Nigeria's Current Fiscal Structure

Nigeria's fiscal arrangement is one of the most centralized in the world.

Oil & Gas Revenues: Collected almost entirely by the federal government, then redistributed via the Federation Account Allocation Committee (FAAC).

Value Added Tax (VAT): Collected federally and shared, often to the advantage of states that contribute less but consume more.



Internally Generated Revenue (IGR): Highly uneven — Lagos alone generates more IGR than 30 other states combined.

This arrangement has created a “feeding bottle federalism,” where states wait for monthly allocations from Abuja instead of building local capacity.

### Historical Context: From Derivation to Distribution

In the First Republic (1960–1966), the principle of derivation guided fiscal relations. Regions kept 50% of revenues from their resources, remitting a share to the center. This fueled healthy competition and innovation — cocoa in the West, groundnuts in the North, palm oil in the East.

Over time, successive military regimes eroded derivation in favor of population- and equality-based sharing.

Today, derivation for oil-producing states stands at only 13%, far below the levels that once sustained balanced development.

Visual Aid: Table 5.1 – Evolution of Revenue Allocation in Nigeria

| Period                   | Derivation Principle (%) | Federal Share (%)                       | Notes                               |
|--------------------------|--------------------------|-----------------------------------------|-------------------------------------|
| 1950s (Pre-Independence) | Limited                  | 50–100% (resources retained by regions) | Regions developed autonomously      |
| 1960–1966                | 50%                      | 20%                                     | Strong regional competition         |
| 1970s (Oil Boom)         | 20%                      | 80%                                     | Centralization began under military |



1999 Constitution 13% (oil-producing states) Dominant control by FG “Feeding bottle” system entrenched

Models of Fiscal Federalism for Nigeria

### 1. Derivation-Centered Federalism (Restoration Model)

Return to a 50% derivation formula, allowing regions/states to retain half of what they produce.

Encourages innovation and accountability.

Example: Pre-1966 Nigeria.

### 2. Hybrid Federalism (Balanced Model)

Retain central pooling for national cohesion (e.g., security, infrastructure), but mandate minimum 30% derivation for resource regions.

States diversify internally to reduce over-reliance on oil.

Example: Canada's fiscal equalization system.

### 3. Confederal Resource Control (Autonomy Model)

Each region/nation-state keeps 100% of its resources, remitting an agreed levy (e.g., 15–20%) to sustain a lean central union.

Aligns with demands of Niger Delta activists and restructuring advocates.

Example: Switzerland's confederation model.



Visual Aid: Chart 5.2 – Revenue Allocation Models for Nigeria

(Three comparative bars showing Derivation-Centered: 50%, Hybrid: 30–40%, Confederation: 100% retention with contribution to center.)

### **Benefits of Fiscal Federalism**

**Equity:** Oil-bearing communities retain fairer benefits from extraction.

**Innovation:** States exploit agriculture, mining, tourism, and services.

**Accountability:** Leaders cannot hide under federal allocations; citizens can better demand results.

**Stability:** Reduces agitation for secession by addressing economic injustice.

### **Risks and Mitigation**

**Fear of Northern Marginalization:** As oil wealth diminishes, North must harness agriculture and solid minerals. Solution: phased transition with equalization grants.

**Wealth Gap Between Zones:** Some regions may initially outpace others. Solution: federal equalization transfers (like Canada) to prevent collapse of weaker states.

**Corruption in States:** Risk of governors squandering revenues. Solution: strengthen local accountability and fiscal responsibility laws



## **Conclusion**

Fiscal federalism is not merely an economic arrangement but a political imperative. Unless Nigeria restores resource control and incentivizes subnational innovation, the federation will remain fragile and dependent. The future of Nigeria — or its successor nation-states — depends on embracing a system where wealth is created locally, shared fairly, and invested transparently.

The next chapter explores how such fiscal restructuring intersects with the quest for political restructuring, constitutional reform, and peaceful transitioning into a sustainable governance model.



## CHAPTER 6

# POLITICAL RESTRUCTURING AND CONSTITUTIONAL OPTIONS

### Introduction

Political restructuring in Nigeria is both a necessity and a recurring demand. Since independence, Nigeria has oscillated between promises of federalism and the reality of a highly centralized unitary state. A meaningful transition to nation-states or a genuine federation must confront the constitutional framework that concentrates power in Abuja. This chapter explores possible constitutional pathways and political models for restructuring Nigeria in a peaceful and negotiated manner.

### The Case for Restructuring

The 1999 Constitution — crafted by the military without popular input — entrenched over-centralization. It placed 68 items on the Exclusive Legislative List, leaving states with limited authority over taxation, security, natural resources, railways, and even electricity.

**This design undermines the federal principle.**

It has bred dependency and weakened accountability.



It is increasingly seen as illegitimate by Nigerians across regions.

Restructuring is thus not optional but urgent, as the constitution no longer reflects the realities or aspirations of Nigeria's constituent peoples.

### Key Constitutional Options

#### 1. True Federalism Model (Revised Federation)

Retain Nigeria as one country but revise the 1999 Constitution.

Move key items — such as police, taxation, and mineral rights — from the Exclusive to the Concurrent or Residual List.

Adopt a 50% derivation principle for resources, restoring balance between center and subnationals.

**Outcome:** Stronger states, leaner center, more balanced federation.

#### 2. Regionalism Model (Return to 1963 Constitution)

Re-establish six federating regions aligned with current geopolitical zones.

Regions control their resources, security, and development priorities, while the federal government retains defense, foreign policy, and monetary policy.

Outcome: Competitive regionalism fostering innovation and accountability.



### 3. Confederal Model (Union of Autonomous States)

Create a loose confederation where each region or nation-state maintains sovereignty but agrees to cooperate on limited matters.

Abuja becomes an administrative hub for collective defense, trade, and diplomacy.

Outcome: De facto independence with a cooperative framework.

### 4. Referendum and Secession Option

For groups insisting on self-determination (e.g., Biafra, Oduduwa), a structured referendum process could allow peaceful exit or renegotiated union.

Outcome: Transition to multiple independent states through democratic choice rather than violent conflict.

Visual Aid: Table 6.1 – Comparative Constitutional Models for Nigeria

| Model Features  | Strengths                      | Risks/Challenges                       |
|-----------------|--------------------------------|----------------------------------------|
| True Federalism | Stronger states, leaner center | Balanced unity, retains Nigeria's map  |
| Regionalism     | Six autonomous regions         | Economies of scale, competitive growth |
| Confederation   | Sovereign regions, loose union | Maximum autonomy, peaceful coexistence |
|                 |                                | Weak central authority                 |



Secession/Referendum Democratic exit mechanisms  
Respects self-determination Risk of instability if not managed

### Political Dynamics of Restructuring

**Northern Concerns:** Fear of losing oil revenue and federal dominance.

**Southern Agitations:** Strong push for restructuring to regain autonomy.

**Middle Belt:** Torn between northern identity and southern demands; supports restructuring to escape northern domination.

**Elite Resistance:** Many national politicians benefit from centralization and resist constitutional change.

Thus, restructuring will require elite consensus, grassroots mobilization, and international support to ensure peaceful transition.

### Pathways for Reform

1. **Constitutional Conference** – Convene a sovereign national dialogue where ethnic nationalities negotiate Nigeria's future.
2. **Legislative Amendment** – Use the National Assembly and State Assemblies to amend the 1999 Constitution in phases.
3. **Judicial Interpretation** – Strategic litigation can gradually redefine federal powers.



4. **Popular Referendum** – Ultimately, Nigerians must endorse restructuring through a national vote for legitimacy.

### **Conclusion**

Political restructuring is the gateway to addressing Nigeria's deepening crises. Without a reimagined constitutional order, fiscal reforms and economic innovation will remain stalled. Whether through true federalism, regionalism, or confederation, Nigeria must transition into a structure that reflects its diversity, promotes equity, and prevents conflict.

The next chapter explores security sector reforms, an indispensable component of restructuring, since no transition is possible without peace and order.

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## **CHAPTER 7**

### **RESOURCE CONTROL AND FISCAL FEDERALISM**

#### **Introduction**

**R**esource control and fiscal federalism are among the most contentious issues in Nigeria's federal arrangement. The discovery of oil in the Niger Delta in the late 1950s fundamentally altered the structure of revenue generation and allocation in the country. Before oil, agriculture and regional productivity were the main sources of government revenue, and regions retained substantial autonomy over resources. With oil, however, came centralization of revenue, contestations over derivation, and persistent agitations for resource control.

This chapter examines the history, politics, and implications of resource control and fiscal federalism in Nigeria. It highlights the demand for equity by oil-producing states, the fears of non-oil-producing regions, and the attempts by successive governments to balance unity with fairness.

#### **Historical Evolution of Resource Control in Nigeria**

Pre-Independence & First Republic (1950s–1966):

Regional governments controlled their resources, paying a



portion to the federal government. For instance, cocoa revenues drove the Western Region, groundnut pyramids enriched the North, and palm oil boosted the East.

The 50% derivation principle allowed regions to retain half of what they produced.

### **Military Rule (1966–1979):**

After the Civil War, oil became dominant. Military decrees centralized control, reducing derivation drastically. The Petroleum Decree of 1969 vested ownership of oil and gas in the federal government.

1980s to 1999:

Derivation fell to as low as 1%, while states depended heavily on federal allocations. This centralization created grievances, especially in the Niger Delta.

### **1999 Constitution to Present:**

The 13% derivation principle was enshrined in the 1999 Constitution, but demands for higher derivation and outright control of resources by producing states have remained strong

### **The Case for Resource Control**

Proponents of resource control, particularly from the Niger Delta, argue that:



1. **Equity and Justice:** Communities bearing the environmental degradation of oil exploration should receive greater benefits.
2. **Development Needs:** Producing states suffer underdevelopment despite generating most of the nation's wealth.
3. **True Federalism:** Genuine federalism requires states or regions to control resources and remit taxes/royalties to the center.

### **The Case Against Resource Control**

Opponents, mainly from non-oil-producing regions, contend that:

1. **National Unity:** Allowing states to control resources may weaken the federation and fuel secessionist tendencies.
2. **Economic Disparity:** Non-producing states could become impoverished, worsening inequality.
3. **Dependency on Oil:** Since oil dominates national revenue, the federal government requires control to ensure stability and equal distribution.

### **Current Revenue Allocation Formula**

The revenue allocation in Nigeria is guided by three main principles:

1. Derivation (13% of oil revenue to producing states)
2. Equality of States (all states receive some share regardless of output)



3. Population and Need (more populous states get higher allocations to meet service demand)

The current formula (under review) allocates:

52.68% to the Federal Government

26.72% to States

20.60% to Local Governments

Plus 13% derivation to oil-producing states

### Key Issues and Debates

1. **Environmental Degradation:** Oil spills, gas flaring, and land degradation in the Niger Delta intensify the call for resource justice.
2. **Diversification:** Critics argue that dependence on oil prevents other states from developing agriculture, mining, and industry.
3. **Constitutional Reform:** Many stakeholders believe only constitutional restructuring can address fiscal imbalances.

Visual Aids (to be inserted later)

Table 7.1: Historical Derivation Percentages in Nigeria (1954–1999)

Map 7.1: Oil-Producing States in Nigeria (highlighting Niger Delta)



Chart 7.1: Federal vs. State Revenue Share (1970–2020)

### Conclusion

The debate over resource control and fiscal federalism is central to Nigeria's restructuring discourse. It is a debate between equity and unity, between decentralization and centralization. While oil-producing states demand greater autonomy over their resources, others fear economic marginalization.

### A balanced approach would involve:

Increasing derivation while strengthening national solidarity.

Encouraging diversification so that all states can contribute meaningfully to national revenue.

Reforming federal fiscal arrangements to reflect the principles of justice, efficiency, and sustainability.

Ultimately, the resolution of resource control issues is not merely economic but political—requiring dialogue, compromise, and a commitment to fairness.



## CHAPTER 8

# SECURITY ARCHITECTURE AND PEACEBUILDING IN A RESTRUCTURED NIGERIA

## Introduction

No transition—whether toward truer federalism, regionalism, confederation, or peacefully negotiated independence—can succeed without security and justice. Nigeria's current architecture is optimized for centralized control rather than localized problem-solving. The result is a mismatch between national command and community realities: insurgency in the North East, banditry and rural violence across the North West and North Central, oil theft and piracy in the South South, separatist tensions and sit-at-home coercion in the South East, and urban criminality in the South West. This chapter designs a tiered, lawful, and rights-anchored security system that can operate under any of the political models proposed in earlier chapters.

### 8.1 Principles for a Legitimate Security Order

1. **Subsidiarity:** Security responsibilities should sit at the lowest competent level (community local state/region federal/union).



2. **Civilian Consent & Oversight:** Parliamentary, judicial, and community oversight must check coercive power.
3. **Human Security:** Protection of lives, livelihoods, dignity, and access to basic services—not only territory—defines success.
4. **Rule of Law:** Policing by consent, due process, and proportional use of force.
5. **Interoperability:** Clear doctrines, shared standards, and common communications enable joint operations.
6. **Transparency & Data:** Evidence-led deployment, open metrics, and public dashboards.

## 8.2 A Tiered Security Architecture

### 8.2.1 Force Structure by Tier

| Tier           | Institution                   | Primary Roles                                                | Command & Oversight                              | Illustrative Staffing Ratio     |
|----------------|-------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------|
| Community      | Community Safety Corps (CSCs) | Early warning, mediation, by-law enforcement, victim support | Local councils & Community Safety Boards         | 1 CSC per 1,500 residents       |
| Local/City     | Municipal Police              | Patrols, investigations, traffic, forensics, courts liaison  | Elected Mayors/Chairs, Police & Crime Committees | 1 officer per 400–500 residents |
| State/Regional | State/Regional Police         | Serious crime,                                               |                                                  |                                 |



organized crime, rural security, cyber units Regional Assemblies & Independent Police Authority 1 officer per 800–1,000 residents (plus auxiliaries)

Federal/Union Federal Police & Gendarmerie Cross-border crime, national investigations, VIP protection National Assembly, Independent Police Complaints Commission Mission-based

Defense Armed Forces External defense, counter-terrorism (by request), maritime security Civilian MoD, Parliamentary Defense Committee Threat-based

Intelligence Civil & Military Intelligence Strategic warning, vetting, financial intel Multi-party Oversight Committee; judicial warrants Strict legal limits

Under a confederal or independence model, the “Federal/Union” tier becomes an inter-state compact force operating by treaty; state/ regional forces become primary.

### 8.2.2 Command, Control, and Interoperability

Joint Operations Centers (JOCs) in each zone/region integrating police, gendarmerie, customs, immigration, and civil defense with live data feeds.

**Common Operating Picture (COP):** unified incident, geospatial, and case-management platforms with privacy safeguards.

**Standard Operating Procedures (SOPs):** harmonized use-of-



force continuum, arrest & detention rules, evidence chains, and public order management.

**Accreditation:** National/Union Police Standards Agency certifies training academies and curricula; decertifies non-compliant units.

## 8.3 Lawful Use of Force and Accountability

### 8.3.1 Oversight Ecosystem

Independent Police Complaints Commission (IPCC) at federal/union and state levels; powers to subpoena, prosecute, and publish findings.

Civilian Review Boards at municipal level for pattern-or-practice reviews and stop-and-search audits.

Body-Worn Cameras mandated for patrol units; tamper-proof evidence retention.

Rights-First Training: de-escalation, crowd psychology, trauma-informed interviews, and child protection.

### 8.3.2 Legal Reforms (Model Clauses)

**State Policing Clause:** “Public safety is a concurrent function; states/regions may maintain police services subject to national standards and judicial oversight.”



**Use-of-Force Clause:** Codifies necessity, proportionality, and last resort; mandates after-action review for lethal incidents within 72 hours.

**Detention Safeguards:** Access to counsel within six hours; video-recorded interrogations; strict custody time-limits.

**Data Protection:** Limits on surveillance; warrant requirements; penalties for unlawful data sharing.

## 8.4 Demobilization, Disarmament, and Reintegration (DDR)

### 8.4.1 Target Groups

Non-state armed actors: bandit gangs, oil bunkering networks, separatist militias, violent cult groups, and vigilante formations that exceed lawful remit.

### 8.4.2 DDR Phases & Incentives

| Phase | Actions                   | Incentives/Controls                                                                                             |
|-------|---------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| I.    | Disarmament registration  | Safe corridors, weapon buy-backs, biometric registration<br>Amnesty conditional on disclosure & non-reoffending |
| II.   | Demobilization counseling | Cantonment sites, health screening, trauma counseling<br>Stipends tied to attendance; family support            |
| III.  | Reintegration             | Skills, apprenticeships, cooperatives, job placement<br>Micro-grants, conditional cash; business mentorship     |



IV. Transitional Justice Link Truth-telling, restitution, community service Sentence reductions for full cooperation

**Guardrails:** independent monitoring, community witness protection, and exclusion criteria for grave crimes (which go to special courts).

## 8.5 Border, Maritime, and Resource Protection

### 8.5.1 Joint Border Commands

Tri-border task forces with Niger, Chad, and Cameroon; fusion cells for human trafficking, arms, and cattle rustling.

**Smart borders:** e-manifests, ANPR (automatic number-plate recognition), and risk-based customs.

### 8.5.2 Maritime Security (Gulf of Guinea)

Coastal radar chain, AIS integration, and Maritime Joint Task Groups (Navy + Regional Police Marine Units).

Specialized courts for maritime offenses; traceability for crude oil and condensates.

### 8.5.3 Critical Infrastructure & Resource Corridors

Pipelines, transmission lines, railways protected by Infrastructure Protection Regiments (unarmed guards + armed response teams), with drones for right-of-way surveillance.

Community Benefit Agreements (CBAs) to reduce sabotage incentives.



## 8.6 Preventing and Managing Communal Violence

### 8.6.1 Early Warning / Early Response (EWER)

Community peace committees feeding alerts to JOCs via hotlines and secure apps.

Risk heatmaps updated weekly; deployment triggers with pre-agreed thresholds (e.g., livestock theft spikes, hate speech incidents, market arson attempts).

### 8.6.2 Mediation & Peace Infrastructure

Mobile Mediation Panels staffed by trained mediators, traditional leaders, women and youth reps.

Agricultural corridors with negotiated grazing routes or ranching compacts; water-sharing agreements; climate adaptation funds.

## 8.7 Transitional Justice and Reconciliation

### 8.7.1 Special Hybrid Courts

Fast-track dockets for conflict-related crimes; mixed panels (career judges + community assessors).

Victim-centered remedies: restitution, psycho-social support, and memorialization.

### 8.7.2 Truth & Memory

Regional Truth-Telling Forums documenting abuses across eras (civil war legacies, oil conflict, insurgency).



Official archives and school curricula modules to break cycles of grievance.

## 8.8 Human Capital: Training, Standards, and Welfare

Unified Training Pipeline: 6-month basic academy (law, rights, procedures), 6-month field training with certified coaches.

Specialist Schools: investigations, cybercrime, forensics (DNA, ballistics), GBV units, counter-IED, and maritime interdiction.

Welfare & Professionalization: competitive salaries indexed to inflation, health insurance, housing cooperatives, and an ethical leadership track to prevent corruption and desertion.

## 8.9 Financing and Performance

### 8.9.1 Funding Model

Ring-fenced Security Trust Funds at state/ regional level with citizen oversight boards.

Equalization grants for poorer states; performance-based transfers tied to KPIs.

### 8.9.2 Key Performance Indicators (KPIs)

| Domain           | Indicator                         | Target (3 Years) |
|------------------|-----------------------------------|------------------|
| Lives & Property | Homicide rate per 100,000         | by 40%           |
| Case Handling    | Clearance rate for serious crimes | ≥ 55%            |
| Public Trust     | Quarterly survey trust index      | +20 points       |



Response Avg. response time (urban/rural)  $\leq 10/20$  mins

Accountability Misconduct cases resolved within 90 days  $\geq 90\%$

DDR % demobilized gainfully employed after 12 months  $\geq 60\%$

### 8.10 Sequenced Roadmap (24–36 Months)

1. **0–6 Months:** Legal amendments for state policing; set up IPCCs; establish JOCs; launch EWER network.
2. **6–12 Months:** Recruit & train first cohorts; body-cam rollout; COP platform live in 3 pilot zones; DDR phase I–II begins.
3. **12–24 Months:** Scale municipal police; specialist units operational; maritime chain live; DDR phase III; hybrid courts seated.
4. **24–36 Months:** KPI-linked funding; nationwide accreditation; truth-telling forums and curriculum modules; external audit and course correction.

### 8.11 How the Models Adapt

**Strengthened Federalism:** State/ regional police become primary; federal police focus on interstate crime and standards.

**Confederal Model:** A lean union security compact handles external defense and cross-border crime; regions exercise full policing.

**Peaceful Independence:** Successor states preserve interoperability via security treaties, joint border commands, and intelligence MOUs.



## Conclusion

Security reform is the hinge on which every other reform turns. A tiered system rooted in law, consent, and data can dramatically reduce violence, build legitimacy, and create the trust necessary for any negotiated political settlement—be it a stronger federation, a confederation, or the peaceful birth of new nation-states. The design presented here is modular: it can be adopted wholesale or phased in as political negotiations progress.



## CHAPTER 9

### ECONOMIC TRANSITION PLANS FOR REGIONS AND EMERGING NATION-STATES

#### Introduction

**E**conomics will determine whether Nigeria's restructuring journey leads to prosperity or fragility. Political negotiations alone cannot sustain unity, confederation, or independence without economic viability. Each region or emerging state must demonstrate the capacity to generate revenue, create jobs, ensure food security, and trade competitively. This chapter develops practical transition plans tailored to the geopolitical zones, ensuring they can stand as viable federating units or independent states if the peaceful transition scenario unfolds.

#### 9.1 Principles for Economic Transition

1. **Self-Reliance:** Each region must maximize its comparative advantage in agriculture, energy, industry, or services.
2. **Diversification:** Avoid overdependence on oil or a single commodity; broaden revenue sources.
3. **Equity and Inclusion:** Policies must close gaps between elites and ordinary citizens.



4. **Regional Integration:** Inter-zone trade must remain open, whether under one federation, confederation, or separate states.
5. **Sustainability:** Investments must prioritize renewable energy, climate resilience, and long-term resource management.

#### 9.2 Economic Profiles by Zone

##### North West

**Strengths:** Agriculture (grains, livestock, tomatoes, onions, cotton), vibrant markets (Kano, Sokoto), solid minerals (limestone, gypsum).

**Transition Plan:** Mechanize agriculture, establish export zones for textiles and leather, and harness hydropower from dams.

**Risks:** High population growth, insecurity, climate stress.

##### North East

**Strengths:** Agriculture (sorghum, millet, groundnuts), solar potential, and cross-border trade with Chad, Cameroon, Niger.

**Transition Plan:** Invest in solar energy hubs, irrigation farming, and livestock corridors.

**Risks:** Fragility from insurgency; requires DDR (see Chapter 8).



## North Central

**Strengths:** Agriculture (yams, cassava, rice), mineral deposits (tin, columbite, iron ore, gold), fertile land.

**Transition Plan:** Build agro-industrial parks, invest in solid mineral beneficiation, and establish food-processing clusters.

**Risks:** Farmer–herder conflict and weak infrastructure.

## South West

**Strengths:** Education hub, financial services (Lagos), technology ecosystem, cocoa, tourism.

**Transition Plan:** Expand Lagos–Ibadan tech corridor, boost exports of cocoa and rubber, and develop Blue Economy in coastal areas.

**Risks:** Urban congestion, inequality, environmental pollution.

## South East

**Strengths:** Manufacturing tradition (Aba, Nnewi, Onitsha), diaspora remittances, palm oil, trade networks.

**Transition Plan:** Strengthen manufacturing clusters, expand palm oil value chains, and attract diaspora capital into SMEs.

**Risks:** Separatist tensions and weak infrastructure.

## South South

**Strengths:** Oil and gas, petrochemicals, fisheries, mangroves, ports.



**Transition Plan:** Expand petrochemical complexes, diversify into aquaculture and renewable energy, and establish regional maritime trade hubs.

**Risks:** Oil dependency and ecological degradation.

## 9.3 Comparative Revenue Capacity

Table 9.1 – Indicative Economic Strengths by Zone

| Zone          | Key Exports/Products                      | Revenue Potential (trillion/year) | Strategic Advantage       |
|---------------|-------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------|---------------------------|
| North West    | Agriculture, textiles, leather            | 7–8                               | Export zones & markets    |
| North East    | Solar, livestock, grains                  | 4–5                               | Renewable energy hub      |
| North Central | Food crops, minerals                      | 6–7                               | Agro-mineral base         |
| South West    | Finance, tech, cocoa                      | 12–15                             | Gateway to global economy |
| South East    | Manufacturing, palm oil, diaspora inflows | 8 – 10                            | Industrial base           |
| South South   | Oil, gas, petrochemicals, aquaculture     | 20 +                              | Energy hub                |

## 9.4 Economic Transition Models



### 9.4.1 Strengthened Federalism

Derivation raised to 25–30%.

States encouraged to collect VAT and income tax; federal role limited to customs and strategic industries.

Regional development banks established (e.g., North East Development Bank).

### 9.4.2 Confederation

Zones collect and retain most revenues; union funded by 10–15% customs and treaty contributions.

Regional common markets created for trade in goods, services, and labor.

### 9.4.3 Peaceful Independence

Successor states negotiate currency union or independent central banks.

Bilateral trade agreements ensure free movement of goods and people.

OPEC quota negotiations for oil-producing states; WTO access for all.

## 9.5 Social and Human Capital Priorities

1. **Education:** Technical and vocational training aligned with each region's strengths.



2. **Healthcare:** Regional health insurance schemes with telemedicine support.
3. **Infrastructure:** Rail and road corridors connecting resource zones to ports.
4. **Digitalization:** Regional broadband projects, e-governance, and cashless payments.

## 9.6 Illustrative Visuals (to be added later)

Map 9.1: Resource distribution across the six zones (agriculture, minerals, oil, tech hubs).

Chart 9.1: Comparative GDP contribution by zone.

Table 9.2: Transition model scenarios (Federalism, Confederation, Independence) and revenue implications.

## Conclusion

Nigeria's economic future—whether as a single federation or as multiple independent states—depends on robust, localized strategies that play to the comparative advantages of each zone. The transition must be carefully sequenced, balancing immediate fiscal reforms with long-term structural transformation. Economic viability, not just political will, will determine whether peaceful restructuring or secession strengthens prosperity or deepens fragility.



## CHAPTER 10

### SOCIAL COHESION, CITIZENSHIP, AND IDENTITY IN A RESTRUCTURED NIGERIA

#### Introduction

Every state—federal, confederal, or independent—rests not only on its economy and institutions but also on the sense of belonging and collective identity among its people. In Nigeria, deep divides along ethnicity, religion, and region have historically weakened national unity. For any model of restructuring to succeed, social cohesion and inclusive citizenship must be prioritized. This chapter addresses the challenges and opportunities of rebuilding trust and fostering shared identity in a changing political arrangement.

#### 10.1 The Challenge of Fragmented Identity

**Colonial Legacy:** Nigeria's forced amalgamation (1914) united over 250 ethnic groups under one state without organic consensus.

**Post-Independence Politics:** Ethno-regional competition shaped politics, leading to coups, civil war, and persistent distrust.

**Current Strains:** Perceptions of exclusion, marginalization, and injustice fuel separatist movements (e.g., IPOB in the South East, self-determination agitation in the South West, militancy in the South South).



#### 10.2 Dimensions of Citizenship

1. **Legal Citizenship:** Defined by the Constitution and national laws, conferring rights such as voting, movement, and property ownership.

2. **Cultural Identity:** Belonging rooted in language, ethnicity, religion, and tradition.

3. **Civic Identity:** Shared commitment to the state, institutions, and public good.

The balance between ethnic-cultural loyalty and civic-national loyalty will determine the resilience of any restructured Nigeria.

#### 10.3 Citizenship Models for a Restructured Nigeria

##### A. Strengthened Federalism

One Nigerian passport and legal framework.

Affirmative policies to ensure minority inclusion in governance.

Federal Character principle reformed to prioritize merit with fairness.

##### B. Confederation

Dual citizenship possible: one for the regional state and another for the confederation.

Regional control over residency and land rights, but guaranteed right of movement across the union.



Confederation parliament to define minimum citizenship rights (e.g., education, healthcare, mobility).

### C. Peaceful Independence

New national identities formed around each successor state.

Bilateral agreements for cross-border residence, trade, and protection of minorities.

Diaspora engagement becomes critical for economic and cultural diplomacy.

### 10.4 Tools for Building Social Cohesion

1. **Constitutional Guarantees: Equal rights** regardless of ethnicity, religion, or gender.
2. **Education Reform:** Emphasis on shared history, civic education, and tolerance.
3. **Media and Arts:** National films, literature, music, and digital platforms that celebrate unity in diversity.
4. **Interfaith Dialogue:** Structured platforms for Christian–Muslim collaboration in peacebuilding.
5. **Youth Engagement:** Leveraging Nigeria's youth majority for volunteerism, innovation, and inclusive politics.
6. **Community Reconciliation Mechanisms:** Truth and reconciliation commissions in post-conflict areas (e.g., North East, Niger Delta).



### 10.5 Diaspora and Transnational Identity

**Nigeria's diaspora**—over 15 million people—remains a powerful source of remittances, advocacy, and cultural diplomacy. Any restructuring must:

Recognize dual citizenship where possible.

Create diaspora investment bonds.

Encourage diaspora political participation, either directly or via advisory councils.

### 10.6 Visuals (to be included later)

Diagram 10.1: Citizenship models (Federalism, Confederation, Independence).

Chart 10.1: Levels of trust in institutions vs. ethnic identity (illustrative).

Map 10.1: Zones showing ethnic plurality and cultural overlap.

### Conclusion

Citizenship and identity remain the glue or fault line of Nigeria's future. Economic and political reforms will fail if citizens do not feel included, respected, and represented. The challenge is to transform diversity into strength through inclusive institutions, shared values, and mutual respect. Whether Nigeria remains a federation, becomes a confederation, or evolves into multiple states, the principle of equal dignity for all citizens must guide the



transition. Social cohesion is not automatic; it must be consciously nurtured through policies, education, and cultural integration.



## CHAPTER 11

### GOVERNANCE AND INSTITUTIONAL DESIGN IN A RESTRUCTURED NIGERIA

#### Introduction

Strong and effective governance structures are the backbone of any successful political arrangement. For Nigeria, the persistent governance crisis is not merely a problem of leadership but also of institutional design. The federal structure has concentrated too much power at the centre, weakening accountability and efficiency at the sub-national level. Whether Nigeria moves toward strengthened federalism, confederation, or peaceful independence, institutional reform will be central to ensuring stability, justice, and prosperity.

#### 11.1 The Governance Crisis in Nigeria

**Over-Centralization:** The federal government dominates in revenue allocation, security, and policymaking.

**Weak Local Institutions:** States and local governments often lack fiscal autonomy and administrative competence.

**Corruption and Clientelism:** Governance remains characterized by rent-seeking, patrimonialism, and political patronage.

**Institutional Erosion:** Judicial independence, public service professionalism, and rule of law are frequently undermined.



### 11.2 Principles for Institutional Redesign

1. **Subsidiarity:** Decision-making should occur at the lowest effective level (local before state, state before federal).
2. **Separation of Powers:** Strong checks and balances across executive, legislature, and judiciary.
3. **Accountability and Transparency:** Robust anti-corruption agencies with true independence.
4. **Inclusiveness:** Representation of ethnic, religious, and gender groups in governance.
5. **Flexibility:** Institutions must adapt to evolving political arrangements (federal, confederal, or independent states).

### 11.3 Federalism and Governance Reform

**Fiscal Federalism:** States control more of their resources while paying royalties/taxes to the centre.

**State Policing:** Decentralized police under clear constitutional safeguards.

**Judicial Reforms:** State-level courts with appeal to a federal Supreme Court on constitutional matters.

**Civil Service Reform:** Professionalized state and federal services with merit-based recruitment.



### 11.4 Confederation Model and Governance

**Shared Sovereignty:** Confederation authority limited to defense, foreign affairs, and currency management.

**Rotational Confederation Presidency:** To avoid domination by one region.

**Inter-Governmental Councils:** Coordinating platforms for trade, security, and migration across regions.

**Conflict Resolution Tribunal:** Independent body for disputes between member states.

### 11.5 Independent States Governance Design

**New Constitutions:** Each successor state frames its constitution with citizen participation.

**Presidential or Parliamentary Choice:** Flexibility to adopt the model that fits local traditions.

**Bilateral/Regional Compacts:** For defense cooperation, free trade, and labor movement.

**Nation-Building Institutions:** Truth and reconciliation commissions, national integration boards, and independent electoral bodies.

### 11.6 Visuals (to be prepared later)

**Diagram 11.1:** Governance structures under federalism, confederation, and independence.



**Table 11.1:** Division of powers and responsibilities under each model.

**Chart 11.1:** Comparative efficiency of centralized vs. decentralized governance (illustrative).

### Conclusion

Institutional design determines whether governance serves the people or entrenches elites. Nigeria's future depends on creating systems that distribute power fairly, enforce accountability, and deliver services effectively. In a restructured Nigeria, governance must move closer to the people, allowing for local solutions to local problems while ensuring that higher-level institutions remain strong enough to guarantee security and justice.

Restructuring Nigeria is not merely about changing political boundaries—it is about building durable institutions that promote unity, fairness, and development.



## CHAPTER 12

### ECONOMIC MODELS AND RESOURCE MANAGEMENT IN A TRANSITIONED NIGERIA

#### Introduction

The economic foundation of Nigeria's unity and stability has always been tied to resource distribution and control. Oil revenues, which account for the bulk of foreign exchange earnings, have fueled rentier politics, corruption, and dependency, rather than sustainable development. In any restructuring scenario—federal, confederal, or independent states—the success of the transition will hinge on how resources are managed, shared, and reinvested in people's welfare. This chapter explores economic models that can support equitable growth, resource justice, and long-term prosperity.

#### 12.1 Nigeria's Resource Paradox

Nigeria is rich in oil, gas, solid minerals, and arable land, yet suffers from mass poverty and unemployment.

Oil dependency creates volatility, with national revenues tied to global price swings.

Rentierism has weakened innovation, industrialization, and diversification.



The “resource curse” has aggravated inequality between producing and non-producing regions.

## 12.2 Economic Models for a Restructured Nigeria

### A. Strengthened Federalism

**Resource Control:** States retain 50–70% of revenue from natural resources.

**Derivation Principle:** Producing states receive larger shares, while redistribution funds balance equity for poorer states.

**Diversification Imperative:** Federal incentives for agriculture, manufacturing, ICT, and renewable energy.

**Sovereign Wealth Fund:** Managed transparently to stabilize revenues and fund infrastructure.

### B. Confederation

**Confederal Revenue Pool:** Member states contribute fixed percentages to defense, foreign policy, and shared infrastructure.

**Economic Autonomy:** States pursue independent economic strategies (e.g., Lagos as a trade hub, Niger Delta in petrochemicals, North in agro-economy).

**Trade Agreements:** Free movement of goods and labor guaranteed by confederal charter.

**Regional Development Banks:** Financing infrastructure within each zone.



## C. Peaceful Independence

**New National Economies:** Each state develops a unique economic base.

**Cross-Border Trade:** Agreements to prevent economic isolation.

**Currency Choices:** Options for common currency or separate monetary policies.

**Diaspora Bonds and Investments:** Harnessing remittances for growth.

## 12.3 Resource Management Principles

1. **Equity:** Producing regions fairly compensated without breeding resentment.
2. **Transparency:** Open budgets, extractive industry audits, and citizen oversight.
3. **Sustainability:** Investing oil rents into renewable energy, human capital, and green industries.
4. **Intergenerational Justice:** Reserves and savings for future generations.
5. **Regional Cooperation:** Joint management of shared natural resources (e.g., rivers, grazing routes, borderlands).

## 12.4 Case Studies for Nigeria

Norway's Oil Fund: Transparent sovereign wealth model.



**Botswana's Diamond Revenues:** Long-term investment in education and infrastructure.

**Malaysia's Diversification:** Moving from oil dependence to manufacturing and services.

These models provide lessons for Nigeria's transition.

### 12.5 Visuals (to be prepared later)

**Table 12.1:** Comparative revenue allocation under federalism, confederation, and independence.

**Chart 12.1:** Nigeria's historical revenue sources (oil vs. non-oil).

**Map 12.1:** Distribution of major resources (oil, gas, solid minerals, agriculture zones).

**Diagram 12.1:** Resource governance cycle (extraction ➔ revenue redistribution ➔ development).

### Conclusion

Economic restructuring is the heart of Nigeria's political transition. Without addressing the inequities of resource control, no political settlement can endure. Whether Nigeria remains united or transitions into independent states, the guiding principle must be fairness, transparency, and diversification. The future prosperity of the people lies not in oil alone but in productive economies, sustainable industries, and accountable leadership.



If political restructuring answers the question of “who rules?”, then economic restructuring answers the question of “who benefits?”. For Nigeria, this balance is the only path to enduring peace and prosperity.



## CHAPTER 13

### SECURITY AND DEFENSE ARCHITECTURE IN TRANSITIONED NIGERIA

#### Introduction

Security remains the bedrock of political stability and national survival. Nigeria's fragile security environment—marked by terrorism, insurgency, banditry, militancy, secessionist agitations, and communal violence—exposes the weaknesses of its centralized defense system. A successful restructuring must establish credible, decentralized, and accountable security institutions. This chapter explores the challenges of Nigeria's current security framework and proposes models for defense architecture under federalism, confederation, and independent states.

#### 13.1 Current Security Landscape

**Terrorism:** Boko Haram and ISWAP continue to destabilize the North East.

**Banditry and Kidnapping:** Pervasive in the North West and spreading southwards.

**Communal Conflicts:** Farmer–herder clashes in the Middle Belt.

**Secessionist Movements:** IPOB in the South East, militancy in the South South, Yoruba self-determination in the South West.



Organized Crime: Oil bunkering, drug trafficking, and cybercrime.

The Nigerian Armed Forces and Police remain overstretched, underfunded, and politically compromised.

#### 13.2 Federalism and Security Reform

**State Police:** Empowering states to manage local law enforcement under federal oversight.

**Community Policing:** Grassroots security networks integrated into state police commands.

**Regional Security Cooperation:** South West's Amotekun and similar structures institutionalized.

**Judicial Reforms:** Speedy trials for terrorism, kidnapping, and corruption cases.

**National Guard:** Retained for border protection and counter-terrorism.

#### 13.3 Confederation Security Architecture

**Regional Defense Forces:** Each member state maintains its own military and police.

**Confederal Armed Command:** Limited to external defense, joint peacekeeping, and intelligence coordination.

**Rotational Command Structure:** To prevent dominance by one region.



**Border Security Agreements:** Joint patrols and intelligence-sharing across regions.

**Cybersecurity and Digital Defense:** Confederation-wide strategies against cyber threats.

### 13.4 Independent States Security Design

**Sovereign Armed Forces:** Each independent state develops its own army, navy, and air force.

**Defense Treaties:** Mutual defense pacts between successor states to deter external threats.

**Peace and Security Councils:** Mechanisms for dispute resolution and conflict prevention.

**Regional Military Cooperation:** Joint exercises, intelligence-sharing, and counter-terrorism alliances.

**International Alignment:** Bilateral defense agreements with global powers and multilateral institutions (AU, UN, ECOWAS).

### 13.5 Security Sector Reform Priorities

1. **Professionalization:** Depoliticization of the military and police.
2. **Funding and Equipment:** Adequate budgets, modern weapons, and surveillance technologies.
3. **Human Rights Compliance:** Security forces trained in international humanitarian law.



4. **Intelligence-Led Policing:** Use of technology, data, and predictive analytics.

5. **Civil-Military Relations:** Strengthening accountability through parliamentary oversight and civil society monitoring.

### 13.6 Visuals (to be included later)

**Map 13.1:** Nigeria's security hotspots (terrorism, banditry, militancy zones).

**Diagram 13.1:** Security architecture under federalism, confederation, and independence.

**Table 13.1:** Division of security responsibilities under different governance models.

**Chart 13.1:** Defense spending vs. insecurity levels (illustrative).

### Conclusion

Security is the most urgent challenge for Nigeria and will remain central to its restructuring journey. Without credible reforms, economic and political transitions will collapse under the weight of insecurity. Whether under federalism, confederation, or independence, the goal must be people-centered security: forces that protect rather than oppress, strategies that prevent rather than merely respond, and institutions that build trust between citizens and the state.

A restructured Nigeria must abandon over-centralization and



embrace decentralized, cooperative, and accountable security systems that ensure peace, stability, and development.



## CHAPTER 14

### INTERNATIONAL RELATIONS AND DIPLOMACY OF TRANSITIONED NIGERIA

#### Introduction

No nation exists in isolation. Nigeria's transition—whether into a restructured federation, a confederation, or multiple independent states—will have significant implications for international relations. Africa's most populous country, with vast resources and strategic influence, will be closely watched by the global community. This chapter examines how Nigeria and its successor states can reposition themselves diplomatically, economically, and strategically in the international arena.

#### 14.1 Nigeria's Current International Profile

**Regional Power:** Nigeria has historically led peacekeeping in West Africa (e.g., Liberia, Sierra Leone).

**African Leadership:** Key role in the African Union (AU), ECOWAS, and Pan-African institutions.

**Global South Voice:** Active in the Non-Aligned Movement, G77, and climate negotiations.



**Economic Partnerships:** Strong ties with China, the United States, the European Union, and India.

**Diaspora Influence:** Over 15 million Nigerians abroad, contributing to remittances, culture, and advocacy.

#### 14.2 Federalism and International Relations

A restructured federal Nigeria maintains one foreign policy apparatus.

Stronger subnational units may have trade offices abroad, similar to Canadian provinces.

Nigeria remains the anchor of ECOWAS, with a focus on regional peace and integration.

Greater stability at home strengthens Nigeria's bargaining power abroad.

#### 14.3 Confederation Model and Diplomacy

Confederation retains a common foreign policy for external defense, trade agreements, and diplomacy.

Member states exercise limited diplomatic autonomy, establishing cultural and economic missions.

Confederation Presidency rotates, allowing diverse representation in global forums.



Joint currency and defense policy increase bargaining leverage internationally.

#### 14.4 Independent States and Foreign Policy

Each successor state gains sovereign recognition under international law.

Smaller states may rely more on bilateral alliances and trade partnerships.

Risk of fragmentation could weaken global influence unless states coordinate.

Potential formation of a West African Union to maintain economic and security cooperation.

Opportunities for niche diplomacy: e.g., South South states on energy, South East on trade and entrepreneurship, North on agriculture and Islamic finance.

#### 14.5 Nigeria's Strategic Partners in Transition

1. **United States:** Focus on democracy, counter-terrorism, and energy security.
2. **China:** Infrastructure financing, trade, and strategic investments.
3. **European Union:** Human rights, migration, and renewable energy.



4. **African Union and ECOWAS:** Peacekeeping, trade, and continental integration.
5. **Middle East and Gulf States:** Islamic finance, religious diplomacy, and trade.

#### 14.6 Diplomacy and the Diaspora

Diaspora as soft power agents through remittances, advocacy, and entrepreneurship.

Institutionalization of diaspora voting rights and political representation.

Diaspora-driven diplomacy to project cultural influence (music, literature, Nollywood).

#### 14.7 Visuals (to be prepared later)

**Map 14.1:** Nigeria's diplomatic footprint (embassies, trade missions, peacekeeping operations).

**Diagram 14.1:** Foreign policy structures under federalism, confederation, and independence.

**Table 14.1:** Comparative influence in AU, ECOWAS, and UN under different models.



#### Chart 14.1: Remittances vs. FDI inflows (illustrative).

##### Conclusion

Nigeria's restructuring will reshape not just domestic governance but also its role in the world. A restructured federation may strengthen Nigeria's leadership in Africa; a confederation could balance internal autonomy with external unity; while independent states would redefine influence through cooperation or competition.

In all scenarios, strategic diplomacy, diaspora engagement, and regional cooperation are essential for stability and prosperity. Transition must not mean isolation—it must open opportunities for Nigeria (or its successor states) to be credible actors in the international system.

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## CHAPTER 15

### CONCLUSION: PATHWAYS TOWARD PEACEFUL TRANSITION

#### Introduction

Nigeria stands at a historical crossroads. More than a century after the Amalgamation of 1914 and over six decades after independence, the contradictions of statehood remain unresolved. Ethnic divisions, resource contestations, insecurity, and institutional weaknesses persist, fueling the debate over whether Nigeria should remain a single federation, evolve into a confederation, or transition into independent nation-states. This book has sought to present models, evidence, and pathways for peaceful and constructive restructuring.

#### 15.1 Key Insights from the Analysis

**Historical Foundations:** Nigeria's colonial origins imposed a fragile unity that requires deliberate renegotiation.

**Models of Transition:** Strengthened federalism, confederation, and peaceful independence are all viable—what matters is peaceful negotiation and inclusive dialogue.

**Economy as Anchor:** Without equitable and transparent resource management, no political model will succeed.



**Governance Reform:** Institutions must be redesigned for accountability, subsidiarity, and justice.

**Citizenship and Identity:** Diversity must become an asset, not a fault line, through inclusive citizenship frameworks.

**Security Architecture:** Decentralized, professional, and rights-respecting security institutions are indispensable.

**International Relations:** Nigeria or its successor states must leverage diplomacy, diaspora, and strategic partnerships to remain relevant globally.

#### 15.2 Principles for a Peaceful Transition

1. **Dialogue over Violence:** Transition must be driven by negotiation, not coercion.
2. **Inclusivity:** All stakeholders—ethnic groups, regions, women, youth, diaspora—must have a voice.
3. **Phased Implementation:** Gradual reforms (e.g., resource control, state policing) can build trust before deeper changes.
4. **Constitutional Legitimacy:** Any restructuring must be backed by a legitimate, people-driven constitution.
5. **Conflict Prevention Mechanisms:** Truth commissions, inter-ethnic councils, and peacebuilding platforms must be embedded in the transition process.



### 15.3 Pathways to the Future

Reform from Within: Strengthened federalism with genuine devolution of powers can stabilize Nigeria while preserving unity.

**Confederation as Middle Ground:** A looser union may offer autonomy while retaining shared identity and international leverage.

**Peaceful Independence:** If unity proves unsustainable, carefully negotiated independence for regions/states can avert violent disintegration.

**Hybrid Possibilities:** Nigeria's transition may not fit neatly into one model but draw from multiple frameworks, evolving over time.

### 15.4 The Moral Imperative

At stake is not only Nigeria's survival but the wellbeing of over 200 million people and the stability of West Africa. Nigeria's path will influence African governance experiments, global south solidarity, and the fight for development justice. The moral imperative is to avoid chaos, bloodshed, or collapse—and instead pioneer a peaceful, democratic, and just transition that honors the sacrifices of past generations and secures the hopes of future ones.

### 15.5 Visuals (to be included later)

**Diagram 15.1:** Comparative models of transition (federalism, confederation, independence).



**Chart 15.1:** Summary of strengths and weaknesses of each model.

**Table 15.1:** Roadmap for phased transition (short-term, medium-term, long-term).

### Conclusion

Nigeria's journey is not predetermined. The choices of its leaders, citizens, and institutions will shape whether it becomes a more equitable federation, a flexible confederation, or a constellation of independent states. What matters most is the peacefulness of the process, the inclusivity of the dialogue, and the justice of the outcomes.

This book has argued that restructuring is no longer a question of if, but of how. The time to act is now, before centrifugal tensions explode into irreversible conflict. Nigeria has the opportunity to model for the world how a diverse and complex society can transform peacefully into new political arrangements, balancing unity, autonomy, and justice.

The path forward may be challenging, but with vision, courage, and commitment, Nigeria can transition into a future where every citizen, every region, and every generation can truly say: we belong, we are respected, and we are free.



## CHAPTER 16

### EVALUATING POSSIBLE SCENARIOS FOR NIGERIA'S FUTURE

#### 16.1 Introduction

The future of Nigeria, as established throughout this study, depends on the choices made in navigating its complex political, economic, and social realities. Nigeria's unity, though valuable, cannot be sustained by force or constitutional rigidity. Instead, it must evolve through consent, justice, and institutional reform. This chapter evaluates three plausible scenarios for Nigeria's future transformation — Reformed Federalism, Zonal Confederation, and Peaceful Dissolution into Nation-States — within the framework of peacebuilding, governance, and sustainable development.

The purpose of this evaluation is not to predict one inevitable outcome, but to analyze the comparative feasibility and long-term consequences of each path. These scenarios serve as decision tools for policymakers, scholars, and civic leaders seeking a peaceful restructuring model for Africa's largest state.

#### 16.2 Scenario 1: Reformed Federalism

Under this scenario, Nigeria retains its federal identity but implements deep structural reforms to make the federation functional, fair, and efficient.



#### Key Features

**Constitutional overhaul:** A new people-driven constitution replacing the 1999 military-imposed framework.

**Fiscal devolution:** Federating units gain control over local resources, taxation, and planning, remitting an agreed share to the centre.

**True local governance:** Strengthening elected local governments with budgetary autonomy and development mandates.

**Regional competitiveness:** States or zones develop based on comparative advantages — agriculture, industry, tourism, and technology.

**Security reform:** State police and regional security councils established under federal coordination.

#### Advantages

Maintains territorial unity while redistributing power.

Encourages economic self-reliance and regional innovation.

Preserves Nigeria's global diplomatic influence and trade integration.

#### Challenges

Political resistance from central elites benefiting from current arrangements.



Risk of uneven capacity among federating units.

Requires credible constitutional conference and consensus-building.

### **Feasibility Assessment**

This model is highly feasible within a medium-term framework (5–10 years) if anchored on inclusive dialogue and strong institutional guarantees.

### **16.3 Scenario 2: Zonal Confederation**

This scenario envisions Nigeria reorganized as a Confederation of Six Nation-States, corresponding to the existing geopolitical zones — North-West, North-East, North-Central, South-West, South-East, and South-South — each functioning as a sovereign state but cooperating through a loose confederal framework.

### **Key Features**

Each zone becomes a sovereign nation-state with its constitution, parliament, and judiciary.

A Confederal Council replaces the federal government, handling only shared functions such as defense coordination, foreign affairs, and macroeconomic policy.

Freedom of internal movement, trade, and residence remains guaranteed.

Each confederate state controls its resources and defines its



governance structure (parliamentary, presidential, or hybrid).

### **Advantages**

Empowers regions to pursue governance systems suited to their cultures and aspirations.

Reduces internal political friction and competition for federal power.

Enhances accountability through proximity between leaders and citizens.

### **Challenges**

Requires peaceful renegotiation of sovereignty, citizenship, and asset-sharing.

Risk of inter-zonal inequality without a cooperative fiscal mechanism.

Sensitive negotiations over military assets, foreign missions, and central debt obligations.

### **Feasibility Assessment**

This model is moderately feasible (10–15 years), contingent on mutual trust, negotiated treaties, and transitional guarantees against conflict. It represents a pragmatic middle ground between unitary unity and full separation.



### 16.4 Scenario 3: Peaceful Dissolution into Independent Nation-States

In this scenario, Nigeria evolves into multiple fully independent sovereign states, each emerging from the existing zones or cultural blocs. The process is conducted peacefully through referenda, international mediation, and cooperative disengagement.

#### Key Features

Each new state becomes internationally recognized with its constitution, government, and membership in global organizations.

Bilateral treaties define post-dissolution cooperation on trade, security, and citizenship rights.

Shared institutions like ECOWAS and AU mechanisms support peaceful transition and dispute resolution.

#### Advantages

Allows each nation to self-govern without external imposition.

Ends chronic central domination and political exclusion.

Potentially enhances regional stability if transitions are orderly.

#### Challenges

Risk of border disputes, asset division conflicts, and migration crises.



Requires massive international oversight and consensus among elites.

May weaken Nigeria's global standing and reduce economies of scale.

#### Feasibility Assessment

This scenario is least feasible in the short term, but could emerge organically if other models fail or if the federal centre collapses due to persistent governance failure.

### 16.5 Comparative Evaluation

To systematically compare these scenarios, three criteria are applied: Governance Effectiveness, Political Stability, and Economic Sustainability.

**Table 16.1 – Comparative Scenario Analysis**

| Criteria                  | Reformed Federalism | Zonal Confederation      | Peaceful Dissolution |
|---------------------------|---------------------|--------------------------|----------------------|
| Governance Effectiveness  | High (if devolved)  | M o d e r a t e          | Variable             |
| Political Stability       | High                | Moderate-High            | Low–Moderate         |
| Economic Sustainability   | High                | High (with coordination) | Moderate             |
| Implementation Complexity | Medium              | High                     | Very High            |



Time Horizon 5–10 years    10–15 years    20+ years  
Risk of Conflict    Low    Moderate    High (if poorly managed)

## 16.6 Policy Pathway for Transition

The recommended approach is a staged transition combining the benefits of both federal and confederal systems.

### Phase I (Short Term – 1–5 years):

Establishment of a National Dialogue Conference with equal zonal representation.

Drafting of a New Federal Constitution emphasizing devolution and fiscal autonomy.

### Phase II (Medium Term – 6–10 years):

Implementation of Regional Autonomy Acts and Zonal Development Commissions.

Formation of Zonal Parliaments and Security Councils.

### Phase III (Long Term – 11–15 years):

Gradual evolution into a Confederation of Nigerian States, subject to referenda.

Possible constitutional adoption of a Confederal Charter defining common defense, trade, and foreign policy.



This phased framework ensures peaceful adaptation rather than abrupt rupture.

## 16.7 Visuals

### Chart 16.1 – Comparative Scenario Feasibility Index (2025 Projection)

(To be inserted: Bar chart showing “Reformed Federalism” scoring highest)

### Map 16.1 – Projected Zonal Boundaries under Confederal Model

(To be inserted: Map of Nigeria showing six zones shaded distinctly, labeled as potential confederate states with major cities and resource hubs.)

## 16.8 Conclusion

Nigeria's destiny will not be shaped by wishful thinking, but by courageous, deliberate, and inclusive choices. The evidence points to a clear path: Reformed Federalism as the immediate and most viable model, evolving gradually toward a Cooperative Confederation if necessary.

The ultimate goal is not division, but self-determination within unity — a governance structure that respects diversity while preserving solidarity. Only through such transformation can Nigeria fulfill its historic promise: to be not merely a country, but a community of nations bound together by peace, equity, and shared progress.



## CHAPTER 17:

### SUMMARY AND CONCLUSION

#### 1. Overview

This book, *Rethinking Nigeria: Models for Peaceful Transition to Independent Nation-States*, has examined the Nigerian federation as both a political construct and an evolving socio-economic experiment. Across sixteen preceding chapters, we explored Nigeria's origins, its distorted federal structure, the concepts of decentralization and devolution, and comparative models of governance. We also analyzed the challenges of inequality, regional tensions, fiscal imbalance, and the prospects for a peaceful reconfiguration into self-sustaining nation-states.

At its core, the book argues that Nigeria's crisis is structural, not merely political. The country's present centralized system suppresses local innovation, distorts resource control, and fuels discontent among the federating units. To move toward peace, stability, and prosperity, Nigeria must embrace genuine federalism—anchored in decentralization, devolution, and participatory governance.

#### 2. Key Findings

1. **Colonial Legacies:** The roots of Nigeria's governance



dilemma lie in its artificial creation by colonial authorities for administrative convenience rather than for national cohesion.

2. **Centralization and Dependency:** Decades of military rule entrenched fiscal and political centralization, weakening state and local autonomy.
3. **Economic Imbalance:** The federal revenue-sharing system promotes dependence on oil and discourages internal economic diversity.
4. **Political Stagnation:** Elite resistance to restructuring perpetuates inefficiency, corruption, and conflict.
5. **Comparative Lessons:** Countries like India, Canada, and Kenya show that decentralization and devolution can strengthen unity while fostering development.
6. **Emerging Consensus:** There is growing recognition among scholars, policymakers, and citizens that Nigeria must reform its federal structure to survive as a cooperative union of viable states.

#### 3. Toward Peaceful Transition

The transition from a fragile federation to a community of self-reliant nation-states requires careful planning, dialogue, and legal guarantees. It is not a call for disintegration but for reconfiguration—a move from coercive unity to consensual coexistence.



### **Proposed Framework:**

**Constitutional Reform:** Replace the current 1999 Constitution with a new federal constitution negotiated by the constituent units.

**Regional Consolidation:** Merge current states into economically viable regional blocs.

**Fiscal Autonomy:** Allow regions to control and tax local resources while contributing a fair share to the federal pool.

**Security and Governance:** Establish regional police and judicial systems accountable to local populations.

**Civic Engagement:** Institutionalize participatory democracy at regional and community levels.

This transformation, pursued peacefully and constitutionally, will allow Nigeria to evolve into a federation of cooperative nation-states rather than a forced union of conflicting interests.

## **4. The Vision Ahead**

### **A reimagined Nigeria would feature:**

Economically self-reliant regions pursuing diverse development models.

A federal government focused on coordination, diplomacy, and national defense.



Citizens with dual identity—proudly regional, confidently Nigerian.

Renewed patriotism rooted in fairness, inclusion, and shared prosperity.

The journey may be long, but it begins with rethinking—rethinking governance, equity, and the meaning of unity in diversity.

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## **5. Final Reflection**

If Nigeria is to endure, it must transform. The models proposed in this book demonstrate that a peaceful transition to functional nation-states is not only possible but necessary. Unity imposed by force breeds fragility; unity built on justice and autonomy breeds peace.

Rethinking Nigeria is not an act of rebellion—it is an act of national renewal.



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- Bayero University Bookshop, Kano.
- University of Abuja, Department of Political Science, Public Administration, Abuja, FCT.